



CAMBRIDGE
English

Cambridge

English Qualifications

A2 Key and A2 Key for Schools

Assessing speaking for Cambridge English
Qualifications: A guide for teachers



Contents

Who this guide is for	3
Key terminology	4
How is the Speaking test assessed?	5
Assessing speaking	6
What does the Speaking test assess?	9
What's the difference between the bands?	10
Understanding the assessment criteria	13
Global Achievement	14
Grammar and Vocabulary	20
Pronunciation	28
Interactive Communication	34
Appendix	42
Frequently asked questions	52
Useful links to other materials.....	53

Who this guide is for

Teachers around the world spend many hours evaluating learners’ speaking. This guide is for you. With lots of practical tips and real examples, it will help you to assess and develop learners’ speaking skills in preparation for their Speaking test.



Watch and assess a real example

Throughout the guide you'll see these feature boxes for each assessment criteria. They give links to real examples of speaking tests and to the attached **Appendix** which you can use to help you assess speaking and which you can give to your learners for **self-assessment**.

For each speaking test video we suggest you and your learners:

- Watch **Speaking test videos** and make notes in the tables in the Appendix.
- Try applying the official assessment criteria to the videos by yourself, before you look at the real marks and comments.
- Compare your marks and comments with the examiner comments.

Read the examiner comments to help you understand the marks given, but don't expect to become an expert in assessing speaking skills like an examiner overnight! It takes time to get used to the differences between the bands. Cambridge English examiners go through a lot of training and quality assurance before they qualify as examiners.



Integrating teaching, learning and assessment methods to plan, measure and improve

Throughout the guide there are suggestions on how to combine learning and assessment in the feedback, activities and tips sections.

- ✓ Try the practical ideas and activities and reflect on how these techniques affect learning and teaching in your classroom.
- ✓ Discuss different approaches with learners to understand their preferences and needs, and to find out what approaches are most helpful to them.

- ✓ Read about different assessment and feedback methods.

Key terminology

Language assessment is a specialist field and there is some common terminology which you might not be familiar with. Understanding these terms will help you to use this guide.

Term	Teachers might say ...	Definition
Speaking assessment scales and assessment subscales	assessment / marking scales assessment / marking criteria	Areas which an examiner thinks about when marking the speaking test. For the A2 Key and A2 Key for Schools exam, the scale is divided into the three subscales shown in the table on page 9.
Bands (0-5)	marks / scores / grades	Candidates get a mark for each of the subscales from 0 (lowest) to 5 (highest).
Descriptors	explanations / descriptions of the marking criteria	The bands are based on detailed descriptions of what the candidate can do.
Assessor	Examiner	There are two speaking examiners in the test. The assessor listens and gives marks for Grammar and Vocabulary, Pronunciation, and Interactive Communication.
Interlocutor	Examiner	The interlocutor speaks to the candidates and gives a mark for Global Achievement.
Formative assessment	assessment for learning / classroom assessment / ongoing assessment	Giving learners feedback on their progress during a course, so that they can learn from the feedback.
Summative assessment	end of term test / exam end of course test / exam final test / exam	This is an evaluation of learners' progress up to that point. It is often in the form of exams and tests and gives learners a mark or grade.

How is the Speaking test assessed?

The A2 Key and A2 Key for Schools speaking test consists of two parts and lasts about 8-10 minutes for a pair or 13-15 minutes for a group of three.

Part	Timing	Interaction		Task types	What do candidates have to do?
1	3-4 minutes	Interlocutor ↓ Candidate		A conversation between the interlocutor and each candidate, asking questions to each candidate in turn.	Respond to questions, giving factual or personal information.
2	5-6 minutes	Candidate ↕ Candidate	Interlocutor ↓ Candidate	A discussion between the candidates about a set of images.	Candidates discuss likes and dislikes, and give reasons.

★ Top tips

You can find lesson plans to practise each part of the test on our [website](#).

Assessing speaking

The key to understanding how well your learners' speaking skills are developing is through regular, effective assessment. You could choose a mix of **formative assessment** and **summative assessment** as both contribute to learning. See more information about this on [page 52](#). It's a good idea to use a mix of teacher feedback, **peer assessment** and **self-assessment** to give feedback from a range of different sources and in different ways.

There are activities throughout this guide on assessment and **feedback**.

 **Key terminology**

Peer assessment is when learners give feedback on each other's language, work, learning strategies or performance. [Research shows](#) that people who are similar to the learner in age, gender, first language and learning goals are very motivating as role models.

Self-assessment is when learners decide for themselves if they think their progress or language use is good or not. Developing good self-awareness is important for becoming an effective learner.

 **What are the benefits of peer assessment and self-assessment?**

Peer assessment provides feedback from different perspectives and can help the learner in the role of the **'assessor'** as well as the one receiving the feedback. Self-assessment helps learners understand their own strengths and weaknesses and can make them more independent learners. It can also increase the opportunities for feedback in large classes when it's difficult to give individual feedback to all learners. These aren't a replacement for teacher assessment but should be used alongside it.

 **Top tips**

- Learners need training in doing peer and self-assessment so if it's new to them, don't expect learners to understand how to do it straightaway. It may also be useful to discuss with your learners some of the benefits of different types of assessment.
- Give learners a checklist before a task to make it clear what is being assessed and provide a guide for the person giving the feedback. In this [lesson plan](#) (Reflect task) you can see an example of a checklist for self-reflection which you could also adapt for peer reflection.
- Watch [Speaking test videos](#) with your learners so they can become familiar with what is expected in the exam. There are activities in this guide with ideas for how to do this.
- Use the **examiner comments** alongside the videos to help you understand why those marks were awarded. The more you do this, the easier it will be to assess your learners.
- Do not only practise speaking with exam tasks or practice tests. Learners need practice in the sub-skills of speaking to get better at the tests.
- Include speaking activities, even short ones, in every lesson – this gives you plenty of opportunities to monitor and assess your learners, especially if you have a large class.
- Do one or two complete **sample tests** near exam time when learners feel confident and fully prepared. There are ideas for how to use practice tests in the [Mock Test Toolkit](#).
- Don't expect to cover everything in one lesson. Focus on one or two aspects of speaking for assessment. Make a note of other issues you notice to include in future lesson planning.
- If you have large classes, you could assess speaking using some of these ideas:
 - Group work e.g. projects
 - Group presentations: assess both rehearsals and presentations
 - Dialogues and role plays
 - Mini-speeches: practise in class and assess both rehearsal and presentation. Learners can also send recordings of their speeches.
 - You can find these teaching ideas in our [Cambridge English preparation materials](#).
- You can see lots of ideas for using peer and self-assessment in this webinar: [How to use Integrated Learning and Assessment in your classroom](#).



What does the Speaking test assess?

In the test, examiners assess candidates on their own individual performance and not in relation to each other. The **assessor** and the **interlocutor** give marks for the following criteria / subscales. Each of these will be explained in more detail on the following pages.

Global Achievement	✓ The candidate can communicate about the topics in the test.	Interlocutor
	✗ The candidate finds it difficult to communicate and replies are very short.	
Grammar and Vocabulary	✓ The candidate uses simple grammar and vocabulary accurately and appropriately.	Assessor
	✗ The candidate makes a lot of grammatical mistakes and mainly uses single words and phrases.	
Pronunciation	✓ In general, you can understand the candidate.	
	✗ The candidate is difficult to understand.	
Interactive Communication	✓ The candidate can keep the conversation going with very little help.	
	✗ The candidate needs help to keep the conversation going.	

What's the difference between the bands?

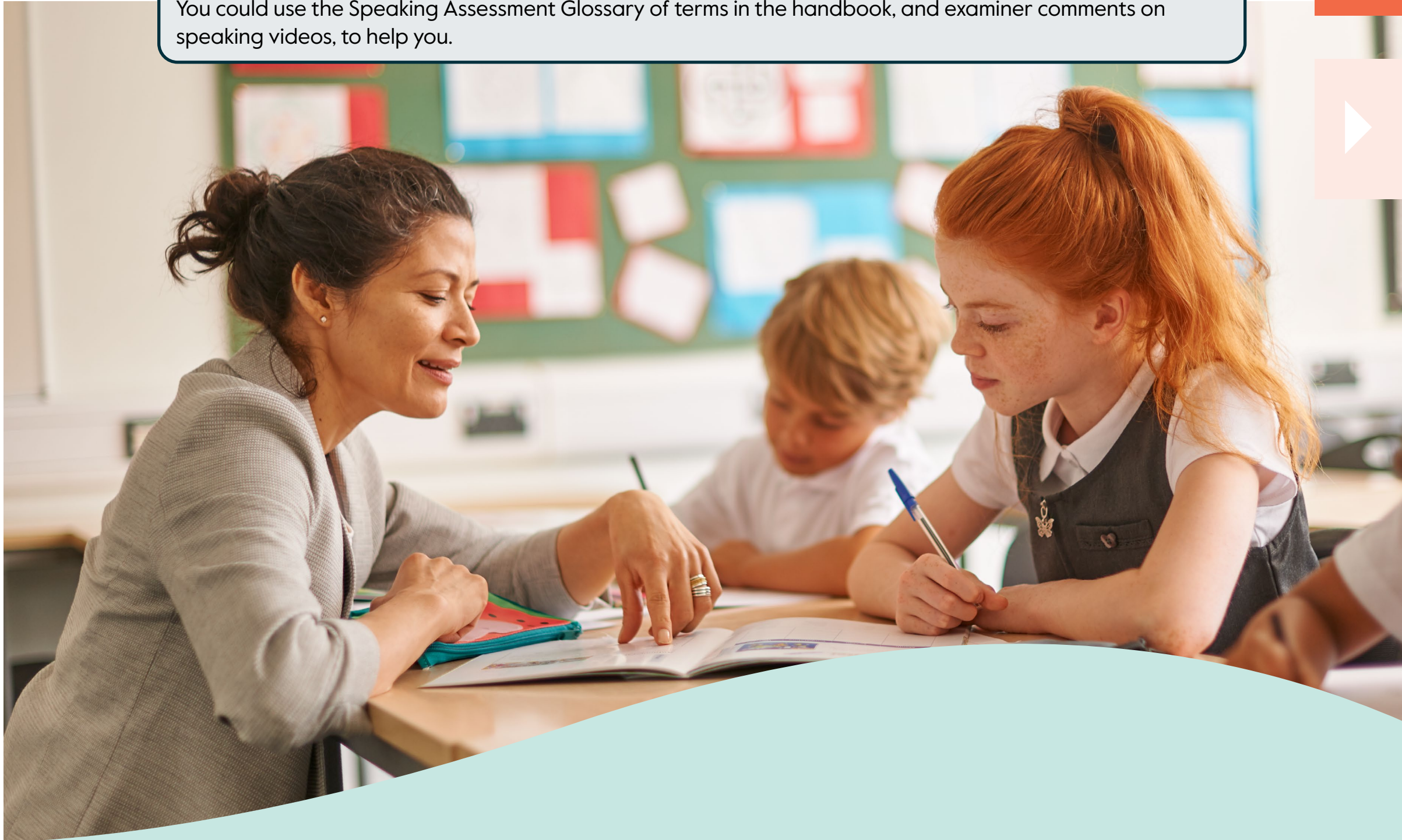
In the Speaking test, examiners give a mark between 0 and 5 (Bands) for each of these areas based on detailed descriptors. Here is an example of the descriptors for Global Achievement at A2 level. Start from the bottom – Band 1 – and read the three texts. Notice how the language in the descriptions varies as you progress up the bands.

A2 Global Achievement	
	Handles communication in everyday situations, despite hesitation.
5	Constructs longer utterances but is not able to use complex language except in well-rehearsed utterances.
	Conveys basic meaning in very familiar everyday situations.
3	Produces utterances which tend to be very short – words or phrases – with frequent hesitation and pauses.
	Has difficulty conveying basic meaning even in very familiar everyday situations.
1	Responses are limited to short phrases or isolated words with frequent hesitation and pauses.

Band 1	Band 3	Band 5
For example, at Band 1 the candidate produces short phrases or isolated words with frequent hesitation and pauses.	At Band 3 the candidate produces utterances which tend to be very short with frequent hesitation and pauses.	At Band 5, the candidate can construct longer utterances despite hesitation.
“ Yes ... er... like eat... errr... the park.	“ I don't like mmm... eating... at home.	“ I like eat in the park because it's... outside.

 Try it yourself!

Look at the other wording in the Global Achievement table on page 14, or other Speaking criteria, and highlight the differences between the bands. Try and think of examples, as above, that fit the different levels. You could use the Speaking Assessment Glossary of terms in the handbook, and examiner comments on speaking videos, to help you.



Focus on feedback

Evidence of progress and actionable feedback

Many teachers are comfortable giving feedback on language but there are many other things involved in being a good speaker, as you will see in this guide.

When it comes to speaking tasks in exams, learners are thinking about the format of the task – especially early on in their exam preparation journey – as well as ideas and the best language to use. It's motivating if you recognise and give credit for different things when they are practising speaking.

For example, if you are practising Speaking Part 2 in pairs, monitor your learners and collect some of the common issues and positives that you hear. For example:

Things I liked

- ✓ Everyone spoke for about two minutes.
- ✓ I heard some good questions: Do you like eating at home?
- ✓ I heard some nice language for likes and dislikes: *I love picnics in the park. / I don't like going to restaurants.*

Things to work on

- ✓ Try to give reasons or examples. For example: I love eating in restaurants **because the food is great!** / I prefer to eat at home **so I can be with my family.**
- ✓ Try and speak clearly so the examiner can hear you.

Notice there are more positive comments than areas to work on. It's important that your learners know when they are doing things well.

Give actionable feedback. Feedback should be specific enough that learners can take action, either to continue to do something they are doing well, or to make changes to improve. Find out more about actionable feedback in this guide.

Tell learners what you'll be focusing on in your feedback before you do a task. This helps them to understand the feedback and gives them a better chance of success.

Understanding the assessment criteria

Developing learners' speaking skills involves a lot more than correcting grammar and pronunciation. This section looks at each of the assessment criteria – Global Achievement, Grammar and Vocabulary, Pronunciation and Interactive Communication – in more detail, and shows you how you can:

- Further develop your understanding of how the Speaking test is assessed.
- Improve your skills of assessment.
- Raise learners' awareness of the speaking assessment criteria.
- Help learners develop their peer and self-assessment skills.



Understanding Global Achievement

What is Global Achievement?

This is a general mark given by the interlocutor. This examiner speaks to the candidates and manages the timing of the test.

Band	Global Achievement	What this means
5	Handles communication in everyday situations, despite hesitation. Constructs longer utterances but is not able to use complex language except in well-rehearsed utterances .	Can understand and speak about the topics and tasks in the test.
		Says more than yes/no or a one-sentence answer.
		Limited and not spontaneous.
3	Conveys basic meaning in very familiar everyday situations . Produces utterances which tend to be very short – words or phrases – with frequent hesitation and pauses.	Situations in everyday life such as having a meal, going to school or work or doing hobbies and other activities.
		Gives very short answers: yes/no or a short phrase.
1	Has difficulty conveying basic meaning even in very familiar everyday situations. Responses are limited to short phrases or isolated words with frequent hesitation and pauses .	Finds it difficult to talk about the topics in the test.
		Answers in words or phrases rather than sentences.
		Pauses and stops a lot.

★ Top tips

- When you assess candidates for Global Achievement, try to think of the 'big picture' rather than counting the number of pauses or the mistakes they make.
- Remember that when you assess your learners, you are giving them an estimate of what they could achieve in the Speaking test. It might not be the same mark as the real test, as test conditions are always different to activities in the classroom.
- Understanding the Global Achievement mark is a good way to start developing your assessment skills as it gives you an overall idea of the candidate's level. Watch an [A2 Speaking test video](#) and complete the **Global Achievement table** in the **Appendix**. Make notes about language as well as how well they talked about the tasks and topics more generally. Compare your ideas to the examiner comments.
- Give learners a variety of speaking tasks, don't just practise exam tasks. Speaking tasks with a clear purpose offer more support than a general 'talk about' task. This also gives learners a reason to listen and respond which are essential skills for the Speaking test. See the suggested activities that have a clear purpose for speaking on page 17.
- Use activities with different interaction patterns such as pairs, threes, small groups and speaking to the whole class.
- Encourage your learners to speak clearly so that they can be heard by both the interlocutor and assessor.
- Give learners preparation time before a speaking task. Give them time to think about what they want to say and what language they could use, as this allows them to upgrade and improve their speaking skills.
- Give your learners opportunities to listen to as much English as possible and a variety of accents. Accents from different varieties of English from around the world are acceptable.

Classroom activities for Global Achievement

Activity 1

Understanding the speaking scales and improving learners' assessment skills

Steps:

- 1. Start by asking learners to discuss in pairs what makes a good English speaker.
Elicit some ideas and organise them into three columns on the board: Grammar and Vocabulary, Pronunciation and Interactive Communication. Don't reveal the names of the columns yet. Here is an example of the answers your learners might give and how you might organise them:

Grammar and Vocabulary	Pronunciation	Interactive Communication
Good vocabulary	Speaks clearly	Good listening
Not making mistakes	People understand you	Answering questions
Correct grammar		
Global Achievement		

Don't worry about the way they phrase things at this stage.
Explain that in the exam, the examiner is looking for these things too.

- 2. Reveal or write in the names of the four criteria as shown above. Explain that learners don't need to remember the headings but they need to understand what they mean.
Explain that Global Achievement = a general mark and today you're going to be examiners and assess some real candidates, focusing on Global Achievement.

Activity 1

- 3. Put the following on the board
fr_ _nds
sh_pp_ng
h_m_
m_s_c
sch_ _l
Ask learners in pairs to try and guess the five topics.
Show the answers friends / shopping / home / music / school. Learners write them in their notebooks.
- 4. Explain to learners you're going to watch a video of Part 1 of a Speaking test ([Humay, Noah and Lucas 0'46"-3'22"](#)). As they watch, they circle the topics the candidates discuss in Part 1.
Show the answers: friends, home and music.
- 5. Ask learners to put their hands up if they think all the candidates passed the test. (Yes, they did.)
Now watch Part 1 again and learners give a score between 1 and 5 for Global Achievement.
Allow learners to discuss with their partner before asking for ideas. You could give them some language to help their discussion such as *I gave them ____ because_____.*
- 6. Reveal the examiner scores (Humay: 4.5, Noah: 4, Lucas: 4) and allow learners to ask any questions. You may want to have this discussion in L1.

Developing Global Achievement

Here are three activities which all have a clear purpose for speaking. You can find further examples in the [Warmers booklet](#).

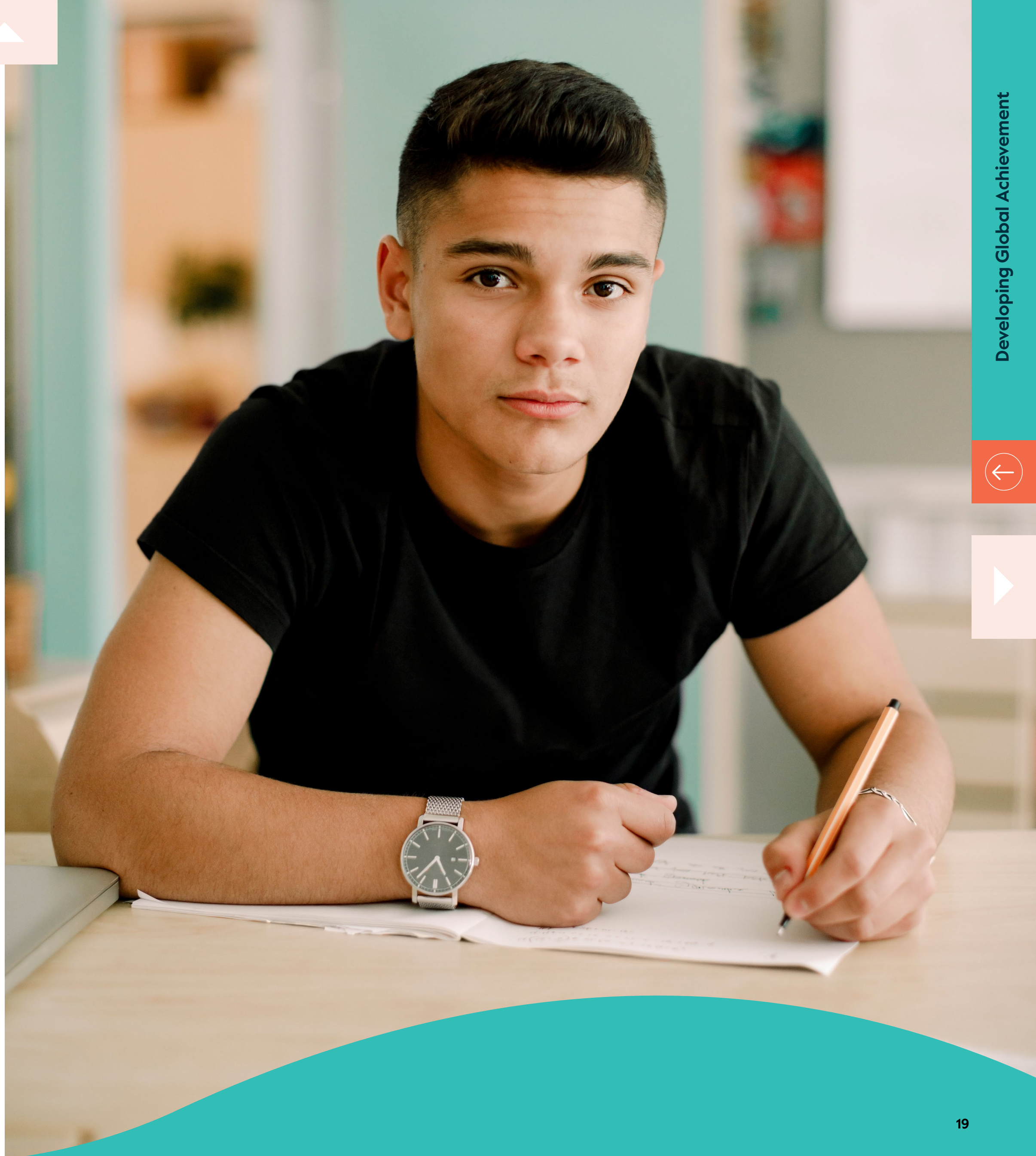
 One-word stories	 Taboo	 Just a minute (in pairs)
Learners make a story as a group. Sit or stand in a circle. Each learner says one word in turn. The story can be as creative as they like. For example: • Yesterday • my • friend • went • to • the • moon	Model the activity by taking a word or phrase on a slip of paper from a set you have prepared (you could use recent vocabulary). Describe it without using any of the words on the piece of paper. Then learners do the same in pairs or small groups. This is a good way to review vocabulary but also to practise saying things in another way (useful when you forget a word).	In this variation, learners have a conversation in pairs for one minute. Give each pair a set of cards with familiar topics. Set a timer for a minute. They take a topic card and have to keep the conversation going for a minute. You can make it harder or easier by varying the time. This can also be done in groups of three.

Focus on feedback

Using the criteria

- **Do it often!** You can use the speaking criteria to give your learners actionable feedback on their speaking at any time, provided they have been speaking long enough for you to hear enough of a sample.
- **Use the tables.** Get familiar with what is expected at A2 level by having the tables with criteria in this guide on hand when you're listening to students speaking.
- **Focus on a couple of criteria at a time.** You might choose to focus more on one or two criteria in a particular speaking activity. For example, you could focus on Interactive Communication and Grammar and Vocabulary in a practice collaborative task.
- **Vary feedback.** Make sure you give feedback on all the different criteria, not just Grammar and Vocabulary. Learners need to know how they are performing in all areas so that they can do their best in the speaking examination.
- **Give balanced feedback.** As well as giving specific suggestions on how to improve, highlight examples of good language for their level. You can also use the recordings to identify where more complex language could be used, and provide specific examples.

Read the section on actionable feedback in the [Cambridge Guide to Integrating Learning and Assessment](#).



Understanding Grammar and Vocabulary

What is Grammar and Vocabulary?

This covers the grammatical structures and words and phrases that candidates use in the test. This is the area that learners are probably most familiar with and expect their speaking to be assessed on. However, it's still useful for them to understand exactly how they are assessed.

Band	Grammar and Vocabulary	What this means
5	Shows a good degree of control of simple grammatical forms. Uses a range of appropriate vocabulary when talking about everyday situations.	Uses accurately and with few mistakes.
		Different forms of words, phrases, basic tenses and simple clauses.
		A variety of words and phrases which are relevant to the topics.
3	Shows sufficient control of simple grammatical forms. Uses appropriate vocabulary to talk about everyday situations.	Can sometimes use accurately.
		Situations in everyday life such as having a meal, going to school or work or doing hobbies and other activities.
1	Shows only limited control of a few grammatical forms. Uses a vocabulary of isolated words and phrases.	Rarely uses accurately.
		Mainly uses single words and phrases.

Grammar and Vocabulary in practice

Here are some examples of differences between the bands in Grammar and Vocabulary.

Band 1	Band 3	Band 5
At Band 1, the candidate has limited control of a few grammatical forms.	At Band 3, the candidate has sufficient control of simple grammatical forms.	At Band 5, the candidate has a good degree of control of simple grammatical forms
“ Music I no like.	“ I listen music every day. My favourite singer Taylor Swift.	“ I love listening to music. I listen with my friends.



Watch and assess a real example

Watch **Humay, Noah and Lucas**. Before you watch it, think to yourself what sort of simple grammar A2 Key and A2 Key for Schools learners can use and also the range of vocabulary they are learning at this level.

Complete the Grammar and Vocabulary table in the **Appendix**. Write examples of the language they use.

Was one candidate better than the other in this area?

Compare your notes with the **examiner comments**, then compare your scores.





My learners are always worried about making mistakes. Is it okay if they make mistakes in the test?

“

Learners will always make mistakes and this is normal but, as you can see from the descriptors, examiners are looking for ‘sufficient control’ or ‘a good degree of control’ – this does not mean ‘perfect’. Developing learners’ skills and highlighting how they can gain marks in other areas (not just Grammar and Vocabulary) can reassure them and boost confidence.

Developing Grammar and Vocabulary

This is likely to be the area you are most familiar with and have lots of ideas for developing your learners’ skills in these areas.

★ Top tips

- Regularly review new grammar and vocabulary. Learners need frequent practice of new language to be able to incorporate it into their speaking naturally and comfortably.
- Don’t expect complete **accuracy** when speaking. Allow for minor errors which do not affect communication. Focusing too much on errors can affect learners’ confidence in speaking.
- Avoid interrupting learners when they are speaking unless there is a complete breakdown in communication. Interrupting to make corrections or offer suggestions can have a negative impact on learners’ confidence and affect the flow of what they are saying.
- Encourage learners to become aware of and correct their own errors. This will help them with accuracy and control. For example, collect common errors while monitoring a large group and write them on the board. After the speaking activity, ask learners to try and correct the mistakes in pairs. **Search our teacher resources for more ideas.**

📖 Key terminology

Accuracy refers to how correct a learner’s grammar, vocabulary and pronunciation are when they are speaking. When developing learners’ accuracy, you focus on the type, amount and seriousness of the mistakes and errors they make.

Accuracy can be compared to fluency. **Fluency** refers to how well a learner communicates meaning and can say what they want to say. Activities which develop learners’ skills in fluency, focus on communication rather than how many mistakes they make in grammar, pronunciation and vocabulary.

 Grammar warmers	 Sentence stems	 Circle drills
Start your lessons with questions that review recent grammar. For example, practise tenses: <i>What were you doing this time last week? What were you doing yesterday at 7pm?</i> Or to practise prepositions: <i>What time do you have breakfast? When is your dad’s birthday?</i> Put 3-5 questions on the board and learners ask and answer in pairs. You can also include vocabulary items to review in the questions.	Practise grammar as if it was vocabulary. Give learners sentence stems with grammar structures and challenge them to use them in a speaking task. For example, give learners 4-5 questions on a topic such as ‘school’. Give them 2-3 slips of paper with sentence stems like <i>My favourite _____ is... We usually _____ on Mondays. I like _____ because...</i>	Practise accuracy by repeating the same structure. Stand in a circle and write the question on the board ‘What do you like doing at the weekend?’ Start the drill: - <i>I like going to the park.</i> - <i>She likes going to the park but I like seeing my friends.</i> - <i>Ahmed likes seeing his friends but I prefer playing football...</i> You can use this to practise or review any structure.

Focus on feedback

Research-based tips

It's really important to give your learners feedback on their speaking to build their confidence, highlight their strengths and point out areas where they can improve. Here are some research-based tips to guide you.

What does the research* say?	What should I do with my learners?
Numerous research findings have proven that feedback promotes language learning (Lyster et al., 2013; Ellis & Shintani, 2013; Mackey et al, 2016). The benefits to learners may not be immediate or predictable, but they will take place.	Give formative feedback regularly to your learners after speaking activities.
There is not enough evidence to claim that either delayed or immediate feedback is more effective than the other (Ellis, 2009).	Use a mixture of both depending on the speaking task in question, ensuring that you don't interrupt learners.
Feedback on correct responses is more effective than feedback on incorrect responses (Hattie, 2009).	It's really important to highlight and praise effective language use. Don't just look for mistakes!
It can be useful to highlight where learners have avoided common pitfalls or mistakes. This is likely to benefit both the individual student and others in the class, who will have their attention drawn to the language item in question (Ur, 2012).	Say things like "Well done! You used the past simple correctly when talking about last weekend. You said: I went to my grandmother's house for lunch. Lots of students use the present simple by mistake."

*Cambridge papers in ELT, 2017. Read the research [here](#).

Key terminology

Delayed feedback – waiting until the end of a speaking activity to give feedback. This usually involves monitoring closely and making notes of good language use as well as errors to correct.

Immediate feedback – giving feedback immediately after the learner says something. This can be called 'on the spot' correction.



Classroom activities for Grammar and Vocabulary

Activity 2

Assessing Grammar and Vocabulary with your learners

Steps:

1. Write the word *Holidays* on the board. Elicit a type of holiday such as a beach holiday. Give learners one minute in pairs to think of different places to go on holiday. Elicit some ideas from the group.

2. Show learners the Part 2 pictures from the sample test.



In pairs learners name the different holidays/activities. Provide extra support by writing the first letter on the board next to any pictures learners are having problems with. Add more letters until everyone has named all the pictures. Get feedback from the group and accept all possibilities: camping/going to a campsite, skiing, a beach holiday, hiking/walking/going to the countryside/going to the mountains, going to a city etc. Model and drill pronunciation as necessary.

3. Review what you have to do in Speaking Part 2. Learners discuss in pairs then show the gapped instruction: *Here are some _____ that show different holidays. Do you ____ these different holidays? Say why or ____?*

Learners guess the missing words in pairs. Ask for some ideas then show the answer: *Here are some pictures that show different holidays. Do you like these different holidays? Say why or why not.*

4. Learners watch the first phase of Part 2 (1'51" – 2'49") and tick the pictures Wensley and Janson talk about – They talk about all of the pictures (Activity A).

Review the things learners are assessed on in the Speaking test. (If you haven't already, you may want to do Activity 1 stages 1 and 2 here). Explain that today you're going to focus on Grammar and Vocabulary.

Watch this section again and learners tick the examples of accurate and appropriate Grammar and Vocabulary they hear (Activity B).

5. Ask learners to give a mark each for Wensley and Janson for Grammar and Vocabulary.

Learners hold up their fingers.

Show learners the actual marks.

Activity 2

6. Drill (in groups and individually) some of the examples from the video.

Do you like beach holidays?

What about you?

I like being in the city because everything is very convenient.

I like skiing the best.

Then remove some words and ask learners to say the sentences with their own ideas. Give them some thinking time first.

Do you like _____?

I like _____ because _____.

I like _____ the best.

7. In pairs, learners practise the short conversation, then they swap roles and repeat (Activity C)

A: Do you like _____?

B: _____. What about you?

A: I like _____ because _____.

B: I like _____ the best.

Monitor and write some good examples on the board and some for learners to correct in pairs.

8. Finally, learners practise the Part 2 task in twos and threes.



Can my learners still pass the speaking exam even if their grammar and vocabulary is weak on exam day?



Each of the three criteria are worth the same amount in the speaking exam. So if they score well in these other areas, it's still possible to pass with a lower score in Grammar and Vocabulary.

★ Top tips

- Remember when assessing your learners on grammar and vocabulary you are not looking for perfect accuracy.

Understanding Pronunciation

What is Pronunciation?

The main focus at A2 Key and A2 Key for Schools is whether it is possible to understand the candidate. Pronunciation includes things like word stress, sentence stress, intonation as well as the individual sounds within words, but at A2 level ‘intelligibility’ is key.

Band	Pronunciation	What this means
5	Is mostly intelligible , and has some control of phonological features at both utterance and word levels .	Easy to understand most of the time. Sometimes uses pronunciation features – intonation, individual sounds, word and sentence stress – accurately.
3	Is mostly intelligible, despite limited control of phonological features .	Can occasionally use the pronunciation features above accurately.
1	Has very limited control of phonological features and is often unintelligible .	Difficult to understand for a lot of the test.

Pronunciation in practice

Here are some examples of differences between the bands in Pronunciation.

Band 1 At Band 1 the candidate is often unintelligible . “ And my [unclear] ... listen... [unclear] his music [unclear] speak him...”	Band 3 At Band 3, the candidate is mostly intelligible . “ I listen music every day. I like Americ... [unclear] and pop.	Band 5 At Band 5 the candidate is mostly intelligible , and has some control of phonological features . “ I like listening to music in my bedroom and in the park with my friend. [Note that the stress is not always accurately placed]
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**Watch and assess a real example**

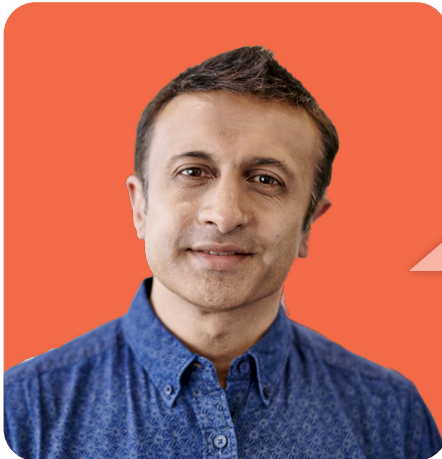
Watch Humay, Noah and Lucas. Complete the Pronunciation table in the Appendix. Write examples of the language they use.
Was one candidate better than the other in this area?
Compare your notes with the examiner comments, then compare your scores.



Developing Pronunciation

★ Top tips

- At A2 level the examiners are looking for intelligibility (being understood) so do lots of drilling at both word and sentence level to help learners imitate the sounds and features of English pronunciation.
- Include activities to help your learners notice pronunciation features as well as practise them. This could be your in own models, drawing attention to good examples from other learners or highlighting them in listening texts.
- Don't forget to use the pronunciation activities in your coursebook. It can be tempting to skip these when you're short of time but paying regular attention to different aspects of pronunciation will help your learners over time. See the activities on page 33.
- Include features of pronunciation (such as stress) when teaching new language - for example, by marking stress with CApital LEtters...) or circles over the word. Remember in English, pronunciation is often not clear from the spelling!
- Make pronunciation visual to support learners. Highlight your mouth position when pronouncing a word, use your fingers to show the number of syllables, use gesture to highlight where to put stress.



Is accent important during the speaking test?

“The focus is on being easy to understand (intelligibility) so don't expect perfect pronunciation or an accent which is like someone whose first language is English. Notice the common problems your learners have which affect understanding or meaning, and work on those. For example, making sure the difference between 'can' and 'can't' is clear.

Drilling	Sorting and categorising	Board game maze
Use drills to model and practise words, phrases and sentences. Try to focus on just one feature such as stress or intonation. Model new language and ask learners to notice where you put the stress, for example. Show this on the board so it's clear. Then model and drill asking learners to repeat in groups, pairs and individually. Vary this by asking 'just people wearing red' to repeat or 'everyone at the back'. This helps to keep learners engaged.	Make sets of cards with words with similar stress patterns or the same sounds. In pairs, learners sort the cards into groups. Monitor and model the words as necessary.	Each square on a board has a different word. Learners have to find a route from the beginning to the end of the board by moving from word to word. You can only move if each word has the same stress pattern or sound. Use the words and sounds that you notice they are having problems with.



Classroom activities for Pronunciation

Activity 3

Assessing Pronunciation with your learners

Steps:

1. Ask learners to complete the questions then ask and answer them in pairs: *Where did you have br_ _kf_st yesterday? Where did you have l_nch on Thursday? Where did you have d_nn_r on Saturday? Where is your favourite pl_c_ to eat?*

Elicit some answers from a few learners.

2. Show learners the Part 2 pictures and elicit the different places to eat: in the park, at school, at the beach, in a restaurant, at home.

Learners listen to Humay, Noah and Lucas doing the first phase of Part 2 (3'22"-5'32"). They number the pictures in the order that the candidates talk about them: 1. at home 2. in the park 3. at the beach 4. in a restaurant 5. at school (Activity A in the [Appendix](#)).

3. Review the areas learners are assessed on in the Speaking test. (If you haven't already, you may want to do Activity 1 stages 1 and 2 here). Today you're going to focus on Pronunciation.

Write on the board: British accent / perfect pronunciation / easy to understand / speaking loudly.

Ask learners to discuss which one they think is most important for getting a good mark in pronunciation.

Elicit feedback highlighting that the most important thing is how easy the candidates are to understand. Having a particular type of accent is not important and learners are not aiming for 'perfect' pronunciation. They don't have to speak loudly but it helps if they try to speak clearly so both examiners can hear.

4. Watch the same section of Humay, Noah and Lucas's speaking test video and learners use the checklist to assess them (Activity B in the [Appendix](#)).

Learners compare their checklists in pairs. Ask learners to justify their answers. Elicit some ideas from the group.

5. Ask learners in pairs to give scores to each candidate. Ask for some ideas then compare them to the examiner marks.

6. Put learners into groups of three and four with one person being the examiner. Learners do the same task and the examiner uses the checklist to assess them on pronunciation.



Focus on feedback

Managing assessment and feedback

- Focus on a few students. When you monitor speaking, it can be useful to focus on assessing a few students at a time. Keep notes about each student to refer back to and ensure you are assessing all your learners.
- Record students. If it's difficult to listen carefully to students in class, you could ask them to record themselves doing a speaking task and send it to you. If you do this, ensure you comply with your local Data Protection and Child Protection laws.



Understanding Interactive Communication

What is Interactive Communication?

This assesses how well candidates interact with each other and the examiner. It includes things like being able to keep a conversation going and how much support is needed from the examiner or the other candidate.

Band	Interactive Communication	What this means
5	Maintains simple exchanges. Requires very little prompting and support.	Can have a simple conversation of question and answer, for example. Very little help from the examiner or their partner.
3	Maintains simple exchanges, despite some difficulty. Requires prompting and support.	May not be able to do this all the time.
1	Has considerable difficulty maintaining simple exchanges. Requires additional prompting and support.	May find it difficult to answer questions or reply to their partner. The examiner may need to help a lot to keep the test going.

Interactive Communication in practice

To see what Interactive Communication looks like in a speaking exam, it's useful to watch and analyse speaking test videos.

Here are some examples of differences between the bands in Interactive Communication.

Band 1 At Band 1 the candidate has considerable difficulty maintaining simple exchanges. “ I like this place because I love eating with my family. - Yes... What's your favourite musical instrument? - Errr....	Band 3 At Band 3, the candidate maintains simple exchanges, despite some difficulty. “ I like this place because I love eating with my family. - Yes, err... restaurant is ... good. What's your favourite musical instrument? - Piano.	Band 5 At Band 5 the candidate maintains simple exchanges. “ I like this place because I love eating with my family. - Yes, restaurant is good, but expensive. What's your favourite musical instrument? - The piano. It's beautiful.
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Watch and assess a real example

Watch [Humay, Noah and Lucas](#). Complete the Interactive Communication table in the [Appendix](#). Write examples of what they say.

Was one candidate better than the other in this area?

Compare your notes with the [examiner comments](#), then compare your scores.



Developing Interactive Communication

★ Top tips

- Use lots of pair and small group activities to encourage participation.
- In speaking activities, encourage your learners to respond to and add to what other learners say. Teach them useful phrases to do this such as: *What about you? Do you agree? I also think...* etc.
- Use speaking tasks with a clear purpose or goal as this gives learners a reason to keep the conversation going.
- Get to know your learners' interests and include these topics in speaking activities. These will be more likely to generate conversation and discussion.
- Remember to practise exam-style speaking tasks in threes as well as twos as this can change the interaction.

 Yes/No game	 Why?	 Anything else?
In this activity one learner asks questions but you can't answer with Yes or No. This means learners have to find other ways to answer which often means avoiding one-word answers. For example, • <i>Do you like chocolate?</i> • <i>I love it!</i> • <i>Are we at school?</i> • <i>We are at school.</i> Demonstrate the activity with the group then learners play in pairs.	Display pictures on a topic on the board. For example, sports, weekend activities or places to go on holiday. Elicit some reasons for liking or not liking them. Demonstrate the activity. Start a sentence eg <i>I love playing basketball because...</i> then throw a screwed-up paper ball to a learner who has to complete: <i>I love playing basketball because it's fun.</i> The learner then starts another sentence – <i>I don't like football because...</i> – and throws the ball to someone else. You can play as a whole class or in small groups.	Give groups or pairs of learners a set of questions on everyday topics such as those in the speaking test. To encourage longer exchanges, after every answer, the questioner has to ask a follow-up question. For example, • <i>Do you like playing football?</i> • <i>Yes, it's great!</i> • <i>Who do you play with?</i> Or • <i>What's your favourite food?</i> • <i>Ice cream.</i> • <i>What's your favourite flavour?</i> Put question prompts on the board for extra support <i>What... Where... Why...</i> etc.

Focus on feedback

Encouraging reflection, self-assessment and peer feedback

- Encourage reflection. Learners can use recordings of themselves speaking to reflect on their speaking subskills – what they did well, and how they think they can improve. Encourage them to share their reflections and questions about their speaking skills with you so that you can add your own observations.
- Use checklists. After a speaking activity, give learners a simple checklist, for example: Everybody spoke. I listened to others. I gave examples and reasons for my opinions. They complete it alone, then compare with their group.
- Give a specific task. Give learners specific things to listen for when doing peer feedback on speaking. For example, for Interactive Communication, ask them to note how often each person speaks. This encourages learners to listen for specific subskills rather than just spotting mistakes. Use the video viewing tasks in the Appendix for more ideas.

Try Idea 16: Peer and self-assessment in the [Cambridge Guide to Integrating Learning and Assessment](#).

Classroom activities for Interactive Communication

Activity 4

Assessing Interactive Communication with your learners

Steps:

1. Lead into the activity by acting out one of the example exchanges from the difference between the bands on page 35. Demonstrate the three different bands and ask learners to vote on which one they think is the best in an exam.

Remind them of the different criteria they are assessed on and explain that today you are focusing on Interactive communication. (If this is the first time you have talked about this with your learners, you can use the first two stages of Activity 1).
2. Explain to learners they're going to be examiners and assess two candidates on Interactive communication.

Put these two questions on the board.
 - Do the candidates understand and answer the examiner/their partner? All the time / mostly / sometimes / hardly ever.
 - Do they need any extra help from the examiner?Elicit ideas for extra help such as repeating a question or asking for more information – why or why not.

Watch Wensley and Janson part 1 (0'38" – 1'46"). Learners think about the two questions. Allow learners to compare their ideas in pairs then get some feedback from the group – In this part they always understand and answer the examiner and don't need any extra help.

You could ask learners to guess their band score at this point by holding up their fingers but don't confirm anything yet.
3. Watch the same section again and learners complete the listening activity on the worksheet. Give learners time to read the questions and try and remember the answers first, then listen and check (Activity A in the [Appendix](#)).

Learners compare in pairs, then feed back.

Ask learners to discuss in pairs: *In general, do you think the candidates give full answers or could they give more information?*

Elicit some ideas and explain you're going to read what the examiner said.

Activity 4

4. Show learners the examiner comments and ask them to guess what the examiner said. Learners circle the answers on their worksheets then compare in pairs. Show the correct answers (Activity B).

Ask learners to discuss in pairs what score they would give for Interactive Communication. (Note that the examiner mark is based on the whole test not just this part)

Reveal examiner scores.

Summarise – they understand and answer all questions easily. They don't need any extra help BUT their answers are a bit short.
5. Elicit some ideas for extending the answers. For example,

What is your favourite instrument? Piano, because my dad plays the piano.

Play the questions and answers from the video and learners in pairs take turns to try and extend the candidates' answers. Play the same question several times and encourage learners to think of different ideas. Try these questions:

Where do you like listening to music? In my house.

How often do you listen to music? Once a week.

What do you like to buy with your money? Electronic goods and items.

Monitor and collect some good examples and some for learners to correct.

Ask a few learners to say their ideas.

Show your examples and ask learners to correct.
6. Put learners into threes. They take turns to be the examiner and practise answering the question with their own ideas (Activity C).

★ Top tips

For other ideas for using the speaking test videos to develop speaking skills, watch this [webinar](#)



Focus on feedback

- Use a variety of techniques and methods when giving feedback. This will appeal to different learners and keep things interesting! Try out some of the ideas on these pages.

Delayed correction

'Delayed correction' is very helpful when you're trying to develop fluency skills. When learners are doing speaking tasks write your feedback on sticky notes or slips of paper and give them to learners after the activity. You can explain the problem on the note or just write the error and ask them to correct the problem with their partner.

Use gesture

Sometimes a look or a hand gesture can help learners when they make a mistake or are struggling to find the right word. For example, gesturing back to show they need to use a past tense. Or a confused look when they have made a mistake. Be consistent with these signs so learners can understand them.

Reformulate and repeat

If a learner is struggling to produce a particular word, phrase or construction, you can say what they need directly. This can help with flow and keeping the conversation going. It's a good idea to get the learner to repeat the piece of language as this will help them remember it.

Key terminology

Delayed correction techniques are used for giving feedback sometime after making the error, such as at the end of a task. These are particularly useful when you want to encourage fluency and don't want to interrupt learners. This contrasts with 'on the spot correction' which happens as soon as the learner makes a mistake.



Appendix

Global Achievement

Use this table to make notes on the candidates' Global Achievement.
Try and write down examples of what they say.
Compare your ideas to the examiner comments.

Global Achievement		
Candidate's name	How easy is it to talk about the topics in the test? How well do they communicate overall?	Can they say more than words and short phrases? How often? How much do they hesitate? A little, sometimes or a lot?

Grammar and Vocabulary

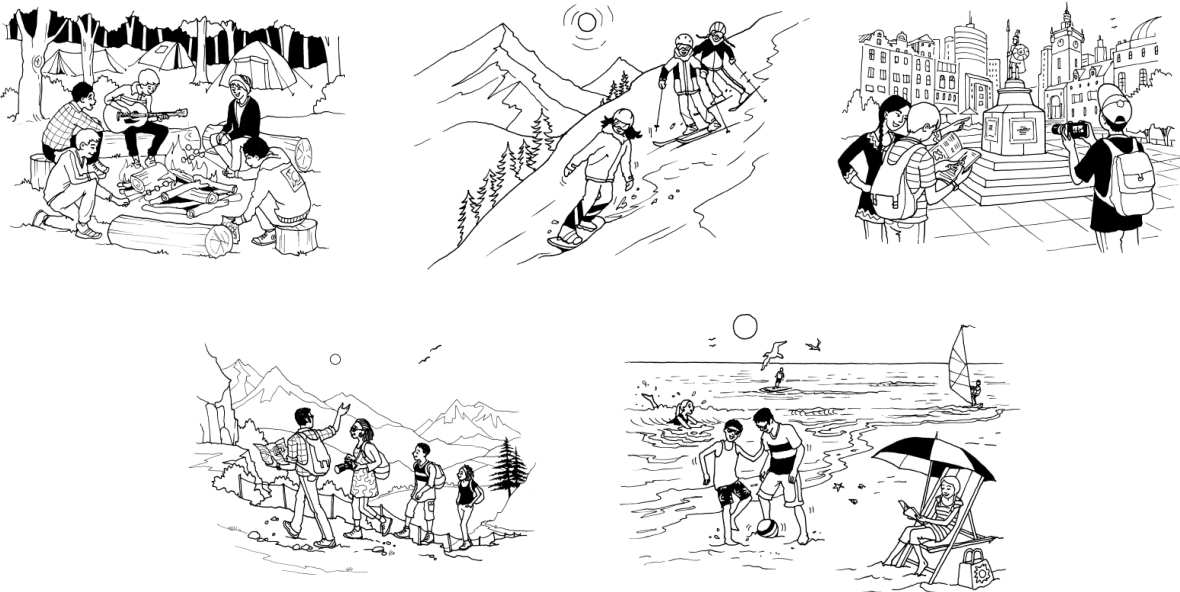
Use this table to make notes on the candidates' Grammar and Vocabulary. Try and write down examples of what they say. Compare your ideas to the examiner comments.

Grammar and Vocabulary		
Candidate's name	Do they use simple grammar accurately? Mostly, sometimes or rarely?	Can they use appropriate vocabulary to talk about everyday situations? Do they use a variety of relevant words and phrases? Or is it limited to single words and phrases?

Activity 2

Stage 4, Learner worksheet

A. Listen to **Wensley and Janson**. Tick the pictures they talk about.



B. Listen to Wensley and Janson again. Tick the things you hear them say.

Wensley	Janson
☐ Do you like camping? ☐ Do you like going to cities? ☐ What about you? ☐ What do you think of the city? ☐ I like being in the city because everything is very convenient.	☐ Do you like beach holidays? ☐ I prefer camping and being outside. ☐ I like hiking the most because I get to spend time with my family. ☐ I like going to the mountains and skiing the best.

C. Practise the conversation with your partner. Then swap roles.

A: Do you like _____?

B: _____. What about you?

A: I like _____ because _____.

B: I like _____ the best.

Answers

Wensley	Janson
☒ Do you like camping? ☐ Do you like going to cities? ☒ What about you? ☐ What do you think of the city? ☒ I like being in the city because everything is very convenient.	☒ Do you like beach holidays? ☐ I prefer camping and being outside. ☒ I like hiking the most because I get to spend time with my family. ☒ I like going to the mountains and skiing the best.

Pronunciation

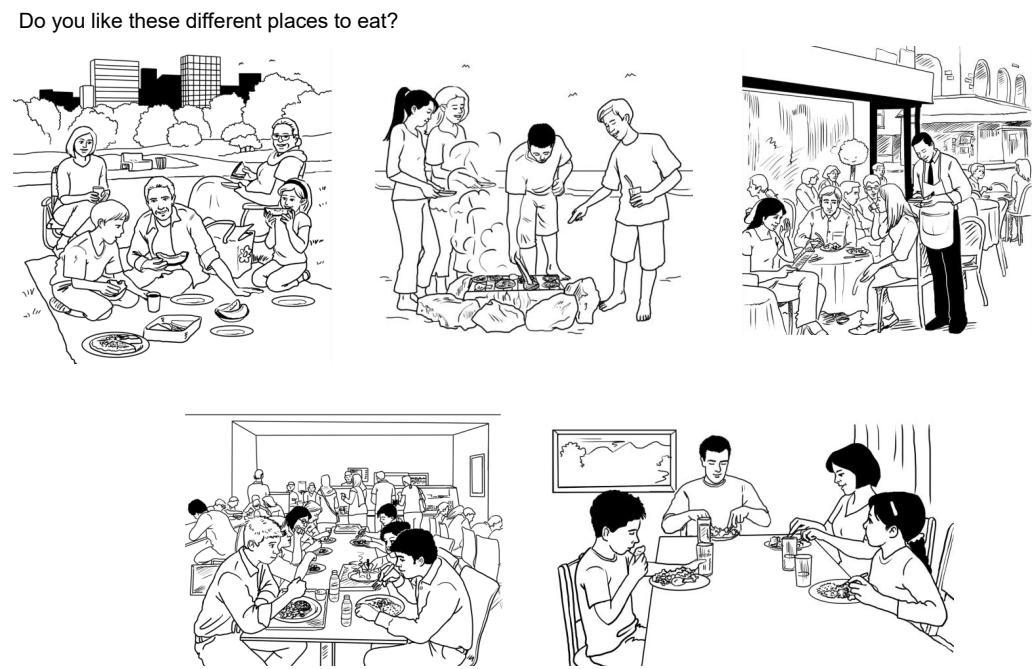
Use this table to make notes on the candidates' Pronunciation. Try and write down examples of what they say. Compare your ideas to the examiner comments.

Pronunciation		
Candidate's name	Can you understand the candidate? Mostly, sometimes or rarely?	Do they use stress, intonation and individual sounds accurately? Sometimes, occasionally or rarely?

Activity 3

Learner worksheet

A. Number the pictures in the order the candidates talk about them.



B. Watch and listen again to their pronunciation. Tick the boxes.

Candidate's name	Is the candidate easy to understand?			Comments/notes
	Most of the time	Sometimes	Rarely	
Humay				
Noah				
Lucas				

Interactive Communication

Use this table to make notes on the candidates' Interactive Communication. Try and write down examples of what they say. Compare your ideas to the examiner comments.

Interactive Communication		
Candidate's name	Can they answer questions and respond to their partner? Easily or with some difficulty?	How much help do they need from the examiner or their partner? Some, a little, a lot?

Activity 4

Stages 3, 4 and 6, Learner worksheet

A. Watch [Wensley and Janson](#) and choose the correct answers.

1. How many times a week does Janson listen to music?

a. 1

b. 2

c. 3
2. What type of music does Janson like?

a. pop

b. classical

c. hip hop
3. What is Wensley's favourite instrument?

a. flute

b. piano

c. drums
4. Where does Wensley listen to music?

a. At school

b. In the garden

c. At home
5. What can Janson buy near his house?

a. comics

b. sweets

c. video games

B. Read the extracts from the examiner comments. Circle the option you think is best.

Wensley gives quick/slow answers. But, they are very short/long.

For example:

What is your favourite instrument? Piano

Where do you like listening to music? In my house.

Janson gives **full/part** answers.

For example:

What music do you like best? I like pop music the most.

Please tell me something about your favourite singer or group. My favourite singer is Justin Bieber.

His replies are only one sentence but they are all **quick/slow**. He can answer all the questions **with/without** any problems.

C. Take turns to be the examiner. Ask and answer the questions.

Let's talk about music.

How often do you listen to music?

What music do you like best?

What is your favourite instrument?

Where do you like listening to music?

Please tell me something about your favourite singer or group.

Now let's talk about shopping.

Where do you like to go shopping?

What do you like to buy with your money?

Who do you like to go shopping with?

What can you buy near your house?

Please tell me something about presents you buy for your friends.

Answers

A. Watch Wensley and Janson and choose the correct answers.

1. How many times a week does Janson listen to music?

a. 1

2. What type of music does Janson like?

a. pop

3. What is Wensley's favourite instrument?

b. piano

4. Where does Wensley listen to music?

c. At home

5. What can Janson buy near his house?

c. video games

B. Read the extracts from the examiner comments. Circle the option you think is best.

Wensley gives **quick/slow** answers. But, they are very **short/long**.

For example:

What is your favourite instrument? Piano

Where do you like listening to music? In my house.

Janson gives **full/part** answers.

For example:

What music do you like best? I like pop music the most

Please tell me something about your favourite singer or group. My favourite singer is Justin Bieber.

His replies are only one sentence but they are all **quick/slow**. He can answer all the questions **with/without** any problems.

Frequently asked questions

What if a candidate asks for clarification or says they don't understand a question, how can examiners rephrase the questions?

Examiners can't explain or rephrase but they can repeat questions and instructions, so it's a good idea to teach your learners phrases like *Can you say that again?* or *Can you repeat that, please?* These are natural in spoken language and will help their interactions in the classroom as well as in the exam.

My students feel intimidated being faced with an examiner. How can I prepare them?

Do role plays and regularly practise tasks with learners being the examiner.

How do formative assessment and summative assessment both contribute to learning?

Formative assessment encourages learners to become more involved in their learning. They think more actively about where they are now, where they are going and how to get there. Teachers also use the feedback to plan the next stages of teaching and learning in ways which will improve learners' performance. Summative assessment can be a very useful guide to progress but should not be the only type of assessment, as there is no focus on how to make further improvements. Both assessment types work together.

Where can I find more Speaking activities?

There are lots of activities in the Speaking sections of [Complete](#) and [Compact](#), our exam preparation courses.

Useful links

Free teaching resources on our website

- [Cambridge Guide to Integrating Learning and Assessment.](#)

Preparation pages contain speaking test videos, examiner comments, lesson plans and sample tests

- [A2 Key Preparation page](#)
- [A2 Key for Schools Preparation page](#)

Speaking test videos

The videos are linked from activities within this guide. You can also find each video in the 'Speaking test video' section on the A2 Key / A2 Key for Schools Preparation page (see links above).

The playlist for all levels of speaking test videos is on this [YouTube playlist](#).

Examiner comments

You can also find examiner comments for each video in the 'Speaking test video' section for the A2 Key / A2 Key for Schools Preparation page (see links above).

Teacher Handbooks

- [A2 Key](#)
- [A2 Key for Schools](#)

Lesson Plans

Some lesson plans are linked from activities within this guide. There are many more lesson plans in the 'Lesson Plans' section on the A2 Key / A2 Key Schools Preparation page (see links above).

Audioscripts are in the sample tests which are linked from the A2 Key / A2 Key for Schools Preparation page (see links above).

- [Mock test toolkit](#)



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